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ADDITION OF BM LINE 3 TO THE EXISTING AUTO-X OPERATIONS, NEAVE TOWNSHIP (KORSTEN) IN GQEBERHA WITHIN THE NELSON MANDELA BAY MUNICIPALITY, EASTERN CAPE PROVINCE

SITE SENSITIVITY VERITIFCATION REPORT

DEDEAT Reference No: ECm1/C/LN1/M/36-2026

24 AUGUST 2026

Applicant:

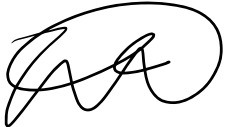


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SITE SENSITIVITY VERIFICATION REPORT: ADDITION OF BM LINE 3

DOCUMENT REVISION STATUS

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DECLARATION OF INDEPENDENCE

I, Zikhona I. Wana, in my capacity as an EAP, hereby declare that I:

- Act as an independent consultant;
- Do not have any financial interest in the undertaking of the activity, other than remuneration for the work performed;
- Have no and will not have vested interest in the activity;
- Have no and will not engage in conflicting interests in the undertaking of the activity;
- Undertake to disclose any material information that has or may have the potential to influence the decision of the Competent Authority (CA) or the objectivity of any report, plan, or document;
- Will provide the CA with access to all information at my disposal regarding the report, whether such information is favourable to the Client or not;
- Based on information provided to me by the Client, and in addition to information obtained during the course of this study, have presented the results and conclusion within the associated document to the best of my professional ability;
- Reserve the right to modify aspects pertaining to the present investigation should additional information become available through on-going research and/ or further work in this field; and
- Undertake to have my work peer reviewed on a regular basis by a competent specialist.



Zikhona Wana

Pr.Sci.Nat (SACNASP)

Reg. EAP (EAPASA)

DETAILS AND EXPERTISE OF THE EAP

Expertise:

Zikhona is a Registered Environmental Assessment Practitioner (*Reg. EAP*) with the Environmental Assessment Practitioner (EAPASA), Registration No. 2019/555, and registered as a Professional Natural Scientist (*Pr.Sci.Nat*) with the South African Council for Natural Scientific Professions (SACNASP) in the field of environmental science, Registration No. 119417. The service provider has over 12 years of environmental consulting experience.

She has undertaken the EA application process in both the BA and Scoping and Environmental Impact Assessment way in several projects. She has also gained experience in other environmental management services undertaking a few responsibilities that include Screening/ Prefeasibility Assessments, Impact Assessments and Drafting of Environmental Management Programmes as per the NEMA. She has also gained experience in undertaking of Waste Storage Registrations, Waste Handling (sorting, screening, shredding, etc.) Registrations, Waste Classification/ Characterisation, Waste Management Licence Applications, and Waste Site Decommissioning processes as is relevant under the National Environmental Management Waste Act 59 of 2008, as amended (NEMWA).

Zikhona has executed several Public Participation Processes as per the EIA Regulations, NEMWA, and the National Water Act 36 of 1998, as amended (NWA).

Her other assignments included Integrated Water and Waste Management Plans. Her experience also includes undertaking General Authorisations, Water Use Licence Applications, Integrated Water Use Licence Applications and production of associated reports in terms of NWA.

Her roles have also exposed her to compiling terms of reference for specialists, commissioning of specialists, and their management as well as the review of specialist reports for alignment with the scope of work and legislative requirements. Her other capabilities include Phase 1 Environmental Due Diligence, Environmental Management Systems, Project Sustainability Management systems, Waste Management Plans, Emergency Preparedness Plans.

Qualifications

- BTech Environmental Sciences
- NDip Environmental Sciences

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ACRONYMS AND ABBREVIATIONS

Auto-X	Auto X – P.E. Manufacturing Facility, trading as Auto-X (Pty) Ltd
BA	Basic Assessment
BM Line 3	Third battery assembly line
AEL	Atmospheric Emission Licence
CBA	Critical Biodiversity Area
DEDEAT	Eastern Cape Department of Economic Development, Environmental Affairs, and Tourism
EA	Environmental Authorisation
EAP	Environmental Assessment Practitioner
EAPASA	Environmental Assessment Practitioners Association of South Africa
ECBCP	Eastern Cape Biodiversity Conservation Plan
EIA Regulations	Environmental Impact Assessment Regulations, 2014 as amended
ESA	Ecological Support Area
km	Kilometre
m	Metre
NEMA	National Environmental Management Act 107 of 1998, as amended
NEMAQA	National Environmental Management Air Quality Act 39 of 2004, as amended
NEMWA	National Environmental Management Waste Act 59 of 2008, as amended
NMBM	Nelson Mandela Bay Municipality
NWA	National Water Act 36 of 1998, as amended
<i>Pr.Sci.Nat</i>	Professional Natural Scientist
<i>Reg. EAP</i>	Registered Environmental Assessment Practitioner
SACNASP	South African Council for Natural Scientific Professions
SANBI	South African National Biodiversity Institute
SSV	Site Sensitivity Verification

SITE SENSITIVITY VERIFICATION REPORT: ADDITION OF BM LINE 3

1. BACKGROUND AND INTRODUCTION

Abantu Environmental Services (Pty) Ltd was appointed by Auto X – P.E. Manufacturing Facility, trading as Auto-X (Pty) Ltd (hereinafter referred to as Auto-X) to conduct a Basic Assessment (BA) for the addition of battery assembly line 3 (BM Line 3) to the existing Auto-X operations. The battery manufacturing facility is located in Korsten (Neave Township) within Gqeberha, under the jurisdiction of the Nelson Mandela Bay Municipality (NMBM) in the Eastern Cape Province (**Figure 1**).



Figure 1: Locality of the proposed site

Auto-X is a holder of an Atmospheric Emission Licence (AEL), reference number 19/2/9/2/1/2/ NMBM AEL 13/36(02), in terms of section 45(1) of the National Environmental Management Air Quality Act 39 of 2004, as amended (NEMAQA) for the production of lead-acid batteries. The licence was issued for lead smelting (sub-category 4.13) and the production of acids (sub-category 7.2) as part of battery manufacturing within the facility.

The licence holder is planning to add BM Line 3 to this facility, as such a variation of the AEL and accompanying Environmental Authorisation (EA) are required. The AEL variation is in line with section 46 of the NEMAQA, while the EA application process is a requirement in terms of section 24 of the National Environmental Management Act 107 of 1998, as amended (NEMA). The licenced activities remain with regards to the AEL, at the same time the BA is conducted as a result of proposed BM Line 3 operation triggering activities listed under the Environmental Impact Assessment Regulations 2014, as amended (EIA Regulations).

2. METHODOLOGY

Regulation 16(1)(b)(v) of the EIA Regulations requires that, when applying for EA, a Screening Report be generated on the national web-based environmental screening tool. Subsequently, the Minister of Forestry, Fisheries and the Environment published the general requirements for undertaking site sensitivity verification (SSV) for environmental themes for activities requiring EA. The purpose is to verify whether the environmental sensitivities identified by the screening tool accurately reflect conditions on the ground.

In terms of these requirements, prior to commencing with a specialist assessment, the current land use and environmental sensitivity of the site under consideration must be confirmed by undertaking a SSV.

In accordance with the requirements, a screening report was generated and identified specific site sensitivities and themes to be assessed for this specific site. The specialist themes discussed in **Section 3.1** were identified.

2.1 Site Sensitivity Verification

The SSV report has been compiled based on:

- A site investigation undertaken on 24th June 2026; and
- A desktop investigation using biodiversity and land-use mapping tools such as, amongst others:
 - South African National Biodiversity Institute (SANBI) BGIS
 - Eastern Cape Biodiversity Conservation Plan (ECBCP) 2019
 - NMBM Bioregional Plan 2015

3. SENSITIVITY OF THE SITE

3.1 Site Sensitivities Identified/ Outcomes of Screening Report

This section entails the sensitivities and the required specialist input identified by the Screening Report (table below).

Table 1: The site sensitivities identified

Category/ Theme	Level of site sensitivity
Agriculture	High
Animal Species	Medium
Aquatic Biodiversity	Very high
Archaeological and cultural heritage	Low
Civil Aviation	Very high
Defence	Very high
Palaeontology	Very high
Plant Species	Medium
Terrestrial Biodiversity	Very high

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3.2 Specialist Assessments Identified

Based on the above listed environmental sensitivities before verification, within the site, the following list of specialist assessments have been identified as per the Screening Report:

- Agricultural;
- Ambient Air Quality/ Air Quality;
- Aquatic Biodiversity including Hydrology;
- Archaeological and Cultural Heritage, including Palaeontology;
- Health;
- Hydrology;
- Landscape/ Visual;
- Noise;
- Socio-Economic;
- Traffic; and
- Terrestrial Biodiversity including Animal and Plant Species.

Therefore, this SSV report is compiled to determine, confirm or dispute the sensitivities identified in the Screening Report and indicate whether Specialist Assessments or Compliance Statements or no further requirements are necessary moving forward.

4. SITE SENSITIVITY VERIFICATION

4.1 Agriculture

In geological terms, the site is predominantly underlain by Kirkwood Formation with a little patch of Peninsula, Pakhuis, Cederberg Formations (**Figure 2** below).

The Kirkwood Formation is part of the Uitenhage Group in the Eastern and Western Cape provinces, primarily within the Algoa and Gamtoos Basins. It formed during the Late Jurassic to Early Cretaceous (approximately 145 to 135 million years), along the southern margin of Gondwana (Muir et al, 2017). The formation is composed of fluvial sedimentary rocks, including variegated mudstones, medium-grained lithic sandstones (often charcoal-rich), and sporadic conglomerates (Muir et al, 2017). It is subdivided into three members, the Swartkops (estuarine sandstones), the Colchester (fossil-rich shales, siltstones, and sandstones), and the Bethelsdorp (marine microfossils in shales and sandstones) as reported by Muir et al (2017).

The Peninsula, Pakhuis, and Cederberg Formations are part of the Cape Supergroup and are significant geological features in the Cape Peninsula (<https://vogelgat.co.za/geology/>). The Peninsula Formation Sandstone, also known as the Table Mountain Sandstone, is a key formation that has given its name to the Table Mountain Group. It consists of hard, light grey quartz arenite sandstone that is resistant to erosion (<https://vogelgat.co.za/geology/>). The Pakhuis Formation is identifiable by glacially deposited pebbles of sandstone (<https://vogelgat.co.za/geology/>). The Cederberg Formation includes dark grey siltstone and silty sandstones, which have been eroded into various structures by the wind (<https://vogelgat.co.za/geology/>).

The soil class comprise imperfectly drained soils, often shallow with a plinthic horizon (**Figure 3** below). The soils that prevail on site have a marked clay accumulation, are strongly structured, and have a non-reddish colour. They may occur associated with one or more of vertic, melanic, and plinthic soils. Their relative wetness is favourable in dry areas, but may be seasonally

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wet in opposite areas.

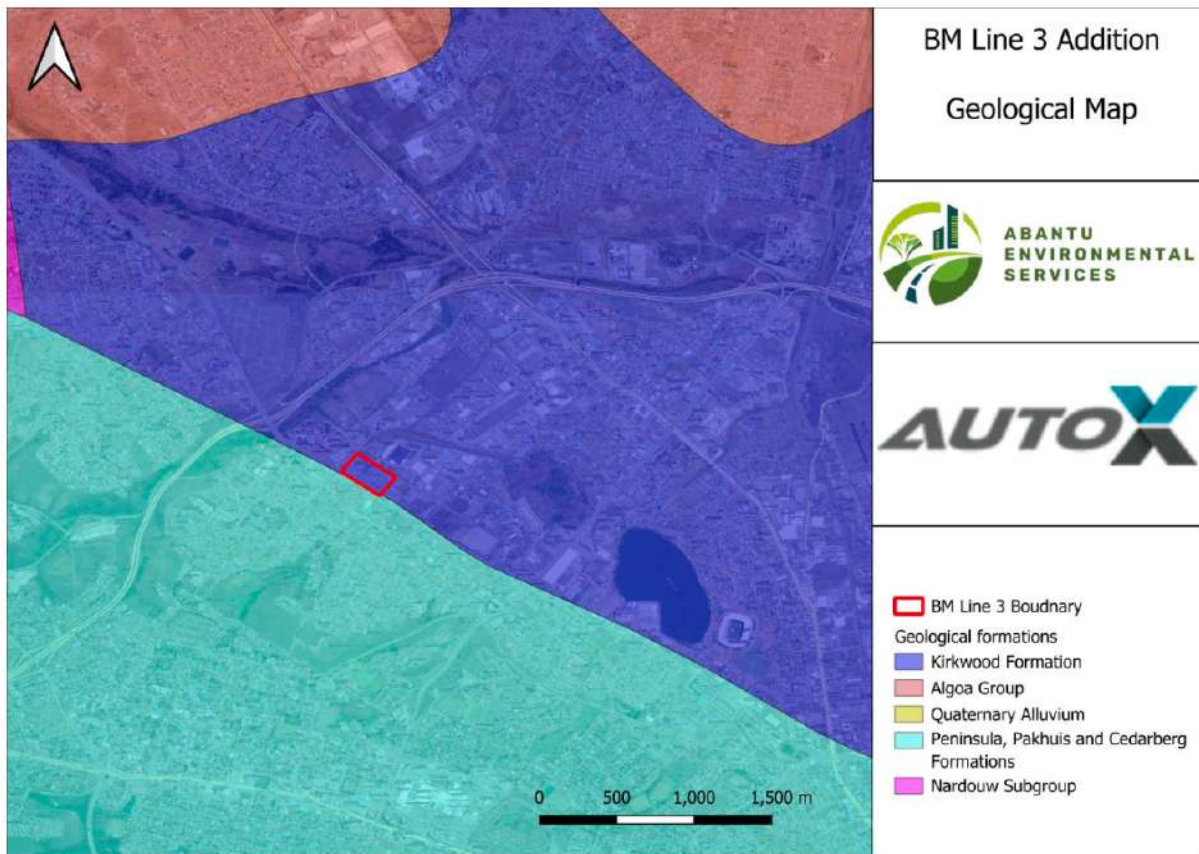


Figure 2: Geology of the proposed site

4.1.1 Sensitivity Verification

According to the Screening Report, the site has a “high” agricultural sensitivity (**Figure 4** below). There are no agricultural activities taking place on site, this has not been the case in more than 30 years as per available historical imagery (Google Earth, 2026). Additionally, the site has had an existing industrial facility for several years. As such, the land on which the addition of BM Line 3 is to be undertaken is already utilised for industrial purposes. Thus, the “high” agricultural sensitivity as depicted in the Screening Report is disputed and revised to “very low to no” sensitivity with no further assessment recommended.

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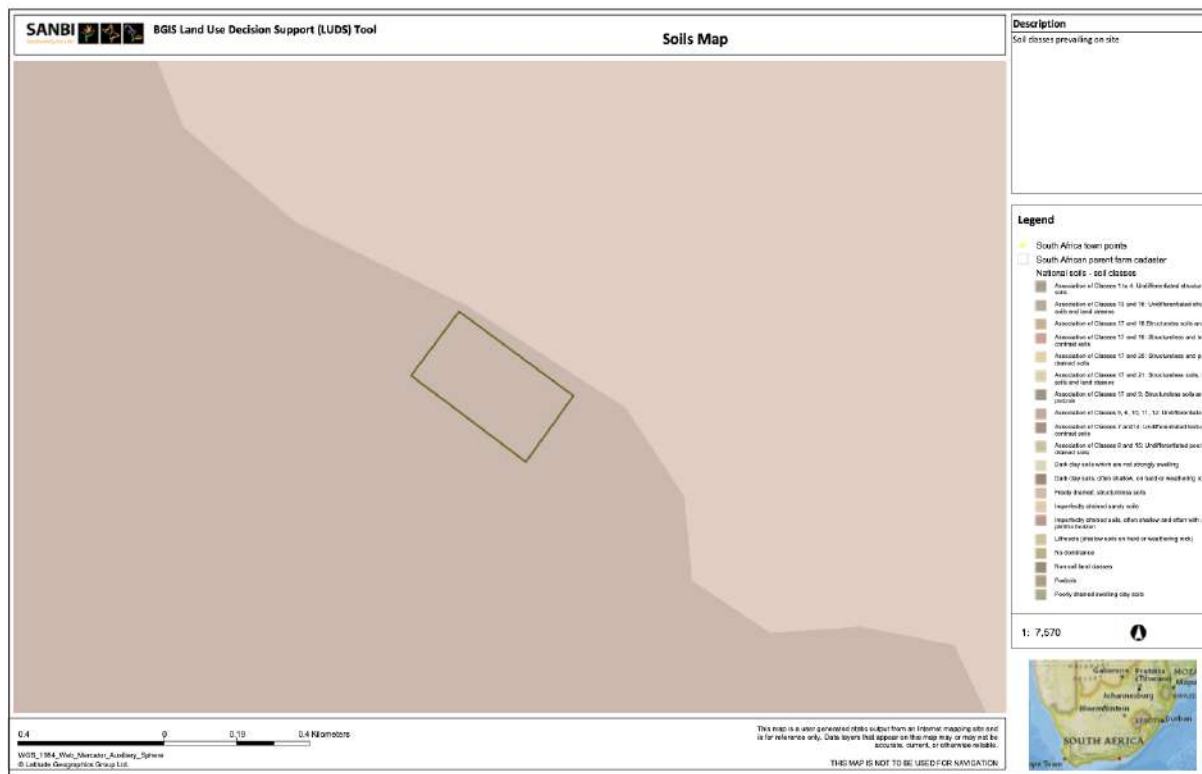


Figure 3: Soil classes prevailing on site



Figure 4: The agricultural theme sensitivity on site as per the Screening Report

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4.2 Aquatic Biodiversity

The land is relatively flat on site, occurring at an elevation range of 40 to 47 metres (m), and slopes towards the east. The site drains by means of surface flow, primarily in an eastern direction towards the existing NMBM stormwater infrastructure. It is expected that groundwater flow mimics the surface water flow.

The site falls within the Mzimvubu to Tsitsikamma Water Management Area. At a desktop level, the site constitutes aquatic Ecological Support Area (ESA) 1, refer to **Figure 5** (ECBCP, 2019). The ESAs are vital regions that support the functioning of PAs and CBAs, playing a crucial role in delivering ecosystem services and enhancing landscape connectivity (SANBI, 2018). The ESAs are defined as areas in a natural, near natural, or moderately degraded condition that are not essential for meeting biodiversity targets but are important for supporting the functioning of the areas referred to above. They are often vital for delivering ecosystem services, which include benefits such as clean water, climate regulation, and habitat for wildlife (SANBI, 2018).

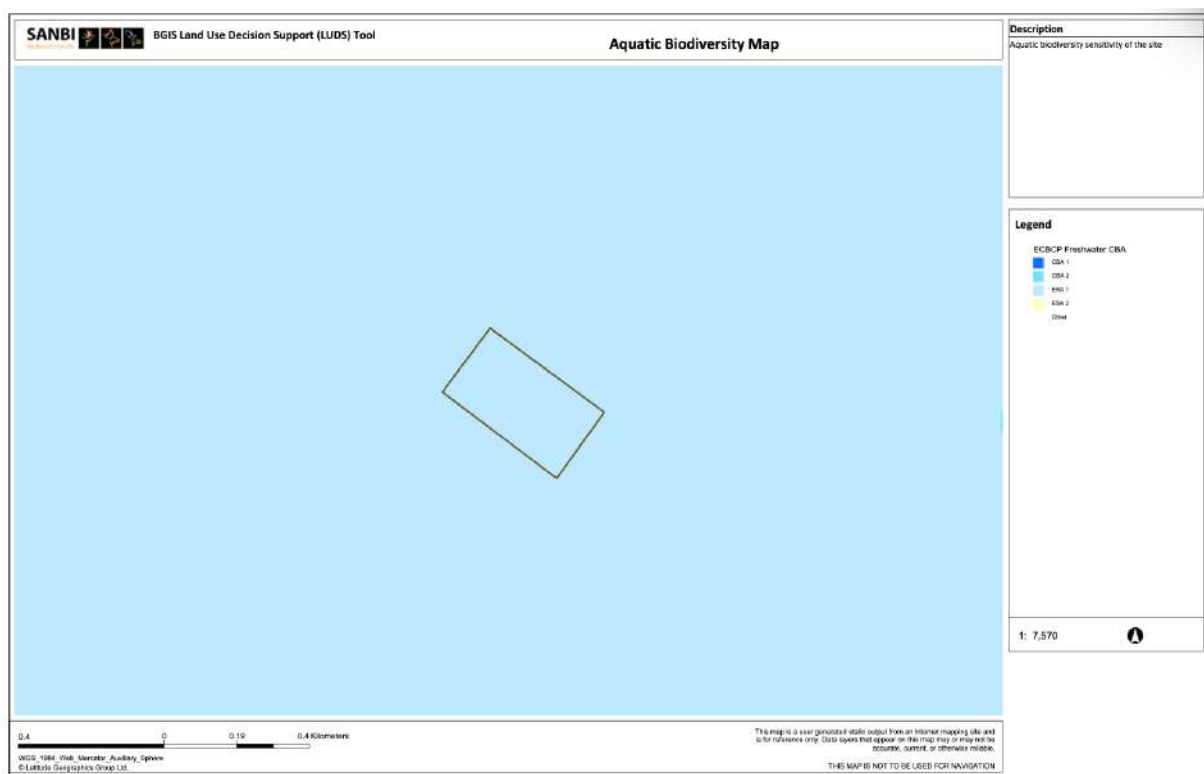


Figure 5: The aquatic sensitivity on site (ECBCP, 2019)

Rivers, Papkuils and Papekuils, around the general area occur more than 175 m from the site. The National Freshwater Ecosystem Priority Area wetlands are located more than 750 m from the site (**Figure 6** below).

The majority of the site extent has hardened surfaces which drain to the existing stormwater infrastructure during rainfall events.

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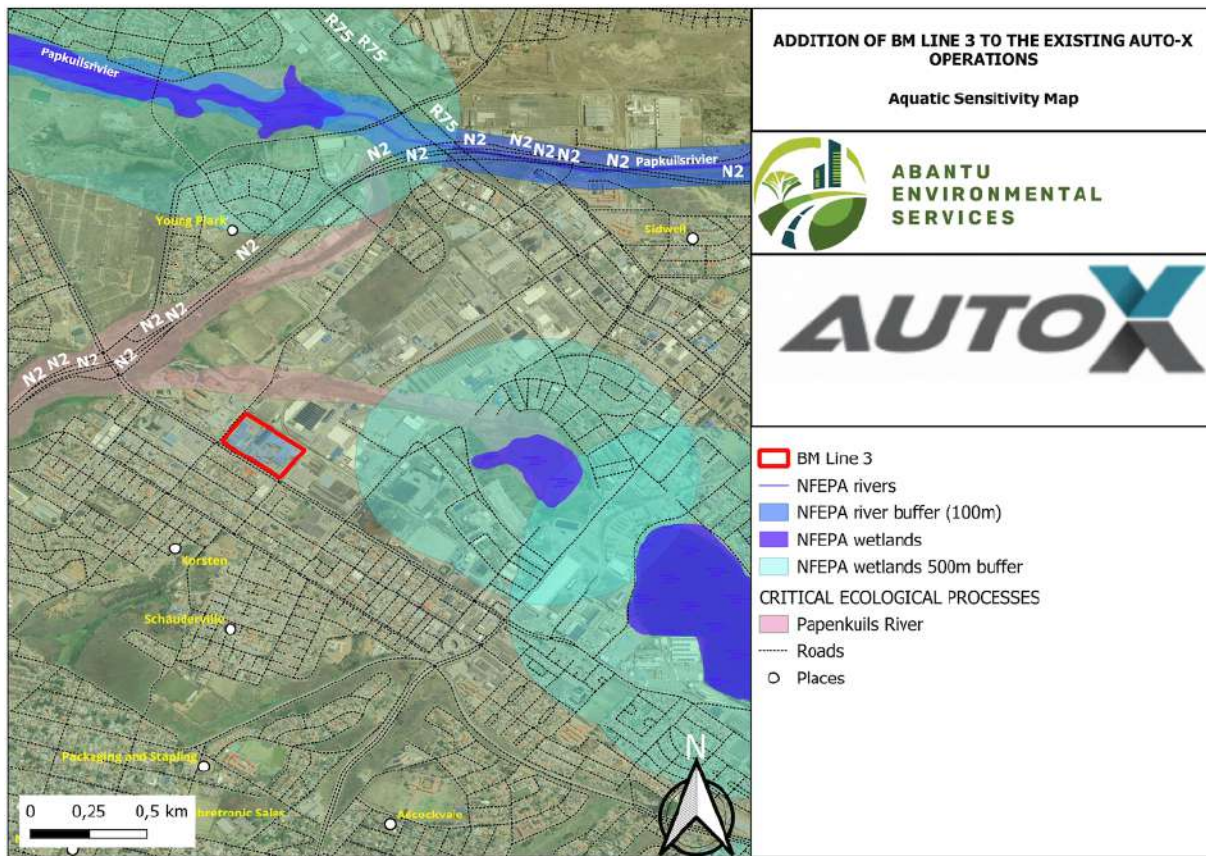


Figure 6: The aquatic sensitivity on site (SANBI, n.d.)

4.2.1 Sensitivity Verification

As reported in the Screening Report, the aquatic biodiversity sensitivity on the site is “very high” (**Figure 7** below). According to the ECBCP (2019), the site is situated within ESA 1. No critical biodiversity area (CBA), nor ecological support area (ESA) exist on site or in close proximity to the site (**Figure 5** and **Figure 6**). As per the site investigation conducted in June 2026, the site is in a developed state and no longer displays the sensitivity referred to. Thus, the “very high” aquatic sensitivity associated with the site due to it being categorised as ESA 1 on a desktop level is disputed. The sensitivity is revised to “very low to no” sensitivity, and the recommendation is that no further assessment is warranted in this regard. This is amplified by the fact that no development will take place on site.



Figure 7: The aquatic biodiversity on site as per the Screening Report

4.3 Archaeological, Cultural Heritage, and Palaeontology

As indicated in **section 4.1**, the site can be summarised as Late Jurassic–Early Cretaceous, fluvial sediments, extremely fossil-rich, part of the Uitenhage Group. The Kirkwood Formation is the most fossil-rich unit of its age, yielding remains of theropods, sauropods, ornithopods, stegosaurs, ankylosaurs, and basal ornithomimosaurids such as *Nqwebasaurus* (Muir et al, 2017). Notable discoveries include the juvenile dryosaurid *Iyuku raathi*, *Paranthodon*, and various reptiles, amphibians, insects, mammals, and plant fossils such as ferns, conifers, cycads, and bennettitaleans (Muir et al, 2017). Mesozoic amber has also been recovered, providing insights into ancient ecosystems (Muir et al, 2017).

4.3.1 Sensitivity Verification

According to the Screening Report, the site features a “low” sensitivity for the archaeological and cultural heritage theme and “very high” sensitivity for the paleontological theme (**Figure 8** and **Figure 9** below). This might be due to the fact that the site is located within the Kirkwood Formation. Although the fossil-rich heritage is acknowledged, the fact is that construction will not take place on site. The “low” sensitivity associated with the archaeological and cultural heritage theme and the “very high” sensitivity associated with the palaeontology theme are therefore disputed and revised to “very low to no” sensitivity and no further assessment necessary.

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Figure 8: The archaeological and cultural heritage sensitivity of the site as per the Screening Report



Figure 9: The paleontological sensitivity of the site as per the Screening Report

4.4 Civil Aviation Sensitivity Verification

It should be noted, however, that the facility has operated on site without any reported or recorded impacts to civil aviation. As such, it is not anticipated that the operation of BM Line 3 will pose any impact to the civil aviation. Thus, the “very high” sensitivity is disputed and revised to “very low to no” sensitivity. No further assessment is necessary.



The Screening Report classifies the defence theme sensitivity of the site as “very high” (**Figure 11** below). However, there are no known military bases/ facilities present within the vicinity of the site. The nearest military facilities to the site are located in Forest Hill and Summerstrand, more than 7 km (in a straight line) from the study area. As such, it is not anticipated that any impacts will emanate from the site to affect this theme. Additionally, the operations are already existing on site and there has been no report of any effect to this theme. As such, the sensitivity is revised to “very low to no” sensitivity and no further assessment required.



Figure 11: The defence theme sensitivity on site as per the Screening Report

4.6 Terrestrial Biodiversity, Plant, and Animal Species

The study area is located within the Albany Thicket Biome. The site falls within the Motherwell Karroid Thicket vegetation/ ecosystem type (**Figure 12** below). The vegetation/ ecosystem type is classified as Critically Endangered (GN No. 2747, 2022). Approximately 9(+3)% of the vegetation type/ ecosystem is protected, with the conservation target at 19% (SANBI, 2018).

As indicated in **Figure 13**, below, the site does not occur within a terrestrial Protected Area, CBA, ESA/ Critical Ecological Support Area, and any other sensitive area (ECBCP, 2019; NMBM, 2009).

4.6.1 Sensitivity Verification

According to the Screening Report, the sensitivity of terrestrial biodiversity and plant species of the site is “very high” and “medium” respectively (**Figure 14** and **Figure 16** below). The Screening Report identifies *Selago polyccephala* and *Justicia orchoides subsp. orchoides* as potentially occurring within the site. The site investigation conducted on 22nd June 2026 indicated that the ground cover on site is paved, with no vegetation (**Figure 17** below).

It should be noted that no vegetation, including animal species, occur on site and, even if they did, the proposed BM Line 3 addition does not include any construction but installation and operation of machinery on the existing warehouse currently utilised for similar activities.

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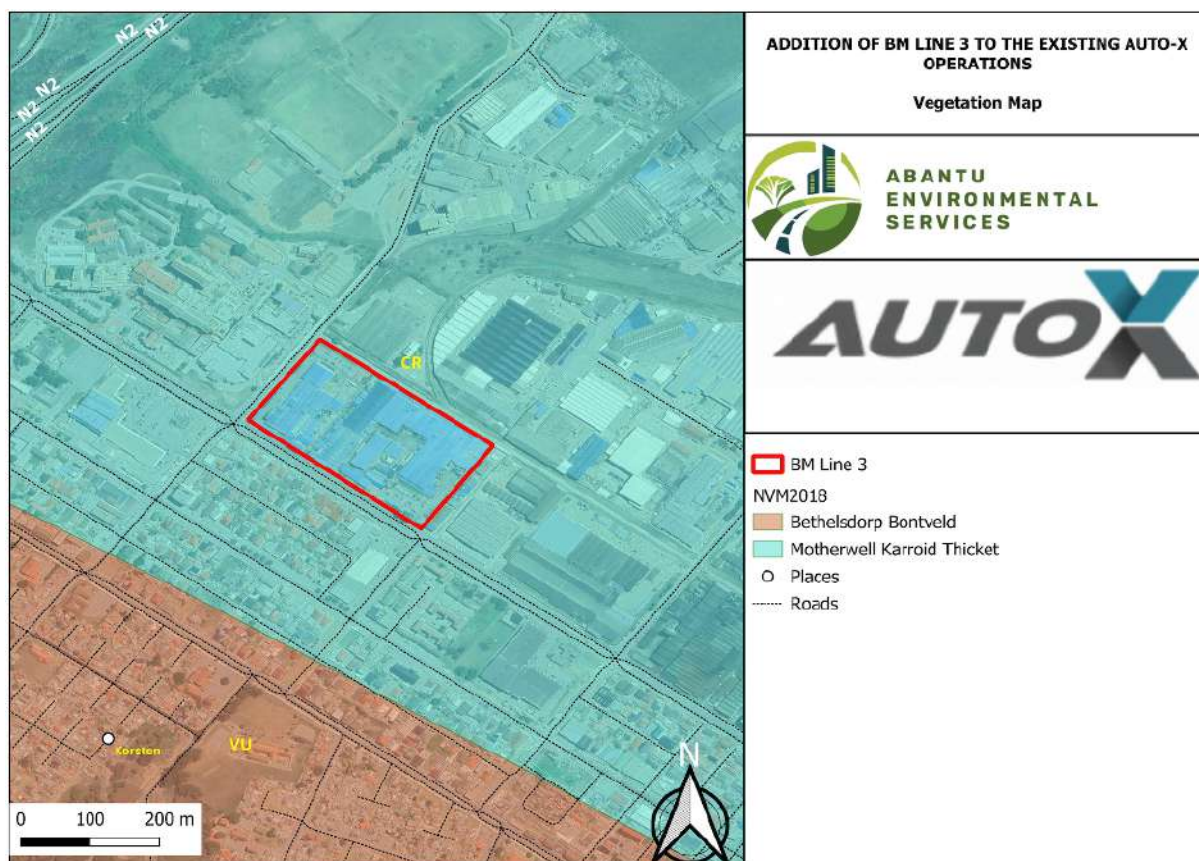


Figure 12: The vegetation type that would have prevailed on site if vegetation existed (SANBI, 2018)



Figure 13: Vegetation sensitivity (ECBCP, 2019; NMBM, 2009)

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The Screening Report flagged the animal species theme, relative to the site, to be of “medium” sensitivity (**Figure 15** below). The potential species that might exist on site are *Actinopterygii-Pseudobarbus afer*, *Invertebrate-Aneuryphymus montanus*, *Mammalia-Chlorotalpa duthieae*, and Sensitive species 13. Given that no vegetation exists on site, it is not possible that animals do prevail on site.

The “medium” terrestrial biodiversity, “medium” animal and “very high” plant species sensitivities are therefore disputed. The ecological sensitivity for terrestrial biodiversity (including flora and fauna) is revised to “very low to no” sensitivity and no further assessment is recommended more so as no construction is associated with BM Line 3.



Figure 14: The terrestrial biodiversity sensitivity on site as per the Screening Report

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Figure 15: The terrestrial animal species sensitivity on site as per the Screening Report



Figure 16: The terrestrial plant species sensitivity on site as per the Screening Report



Figure 17: Ground cover on site

5. SUMMARY/ CONCLUSION

A site investigation was undertaken on 22nd June 2026. The purpose of the site visit was to gather information to develop a complete, comprehensive understanding of the receiving environment, as understood from the desktop, and inform the amendment application process. This preliminary assessment forms the basis against which the application process was conducted. This report also shows that the site is transformed due to the current anthropogenic activity, i.e. battery manufacturing and assembly.

Based on the site verification conducted, it is apparent that the site and the broader receiving environment are completely transformed, with no vegetation remaining. The summary of the site verification, i.e. the identified sensitivities and the Environmental Assessment Practitioner (EAP) recommendations, are indicated in the **Table 2**. Motivation has been included in cases where the identified specialist studies, as per the Screening Report, are not recommended by the EAP.

Table 2: Summary SSV and EAP recommendations

Specialist studies identified as per Screening Report	Indication of whether studies will be conducted (Yes/No)	Motivation for any studies that will not be undertaken
Agricultural assessment	No	The site is not currently utilised for agricultural activities, nor has it been used for such in recent history (1984 to date). The “high” sensitivity is disputed and revised to “medium”; a Compliance Statement is recommended.

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Specialist studies identified as per Screening Report	Indication of whether studies will be conducted (Yes/No)	Motivation for any studies that will not be undertaken
Ambient air quality/ air quality assessment	Yes	
Aquatic biodiversity including hydrology assessment	No	Rivers, Papkuils and Papenkuils, around the general area occur more than 175 m from the site. The National Freshwater Ecosystem Priority Area wetlands are located more than 750 m from the site. The majority of the site extent has hardened surfaces which drain to the existing stormwater infrastructure during rainfall events. Thus, no further assessment is warranted in this regard. This is amplified by the fact that no development will take place on site.
Archaeological, cultural heritage, and palaeontological assessment	No	There are no agricultural activities taking place on site, this has not been the case in more than 30 years as per available historical imagery (Google Earth, 2026). Additionally, the site has had an existing industrial facility for several years. As such, the land on which the addition of BM Line 3 is to be undertaken is already utilised for similar industrial purposes. Thus, no further assessment recommended.
Health assessment	No	To mitigate the potential health risks, Auto-X currently follows crucial safety measures, handles lead-acid batteries with care, and disposes of them responsibly. This practice will continue as part of the BM Line 3 addition. Recycling processes are also practiced, reducing health risks and environmental impact. The operator/ applicant implements and will continue to implement stringent safety protocols, including proper ventilation, employee training, and the use of appropriate Personal Protective Equipment (masks). Regular monitoring of air quality and adherence to safety protocols are some of the current essentials for ensuring the safety and health of workers in this facility. Auto-X is a holder of an ISO 45001: 2018 (Occupation Health and Safety Management System). Thus, a health assessment is not warranted.
Landscape/ visual assessment	No	The site is already an operational battery manufacturing and assembly facility. The operation of BM Line 3 will not have any more effect than currently is the case to the sense of place in the general area. As such, the landscape/ visual assessment is not warranted.
Noise assessment	No	Mitigation measures, i.e. noise absorbers, are in place throughout the facility to absorb sound energy, improving overall comfort in the battery assembly environment. Additionally, it was noted during the site investigation, that the workers around noise generating areas are equipped with noise ear blockers. It is the understanding of the EAP that this practice will continue on site. Due to the fact that the site is already in operation, and this will be a continuation of the operations, the noise assessment is not recommended.
Terrestrial Biodiversity (including Plant and Animal Species) assessment	No	It should be noted that no vegetation, including animal species, occur on site and, even if they did, the proposed BM Line 3 addition does not include any construction but

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Specialist studies identified as per Screening Report	Indication of whether studies will be conducted (Yes/No)	Motivation for any studies that will not be undertaken
		installation and operation of machinery on the existing warehouse currently utilised for similar activities. No further assessment is recommended.
Socio-economic assessment	No	Approximately five-person employment opportunities are associated with BM Line 3 operation. It is the recommendation of the EAP to source these personnel locally. No further assessment is required in this regard.
Traffic assessment	No	As indicated above, the site is accessed from Lindsay and Stanford Road. However, observation was that trucks fetching completed battery batches access the site via Stanford Road only. Trucks were indeed observed parked around the site, along Stanford Road. These were neatly parked such that there was no traffic obstruction on this road. Based on the evacuation of batteries, batch evacuation on completion, truck arrival is known ahead of time and is done only when required. Thus, this practice will continue to be observed as part of the operations on site. Therefore, a traffic assessment is not recommended.

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